stabilizing factor in Asia is the success of India's democracy, as it was India's weakness that tempted the Chinese to come in." Thus India needed to be strengthened and, in the meantime, supported—only that would intensify India and its neighbors' resolve, as well as deter China from another attack.

In his meetings with Radhakrishnan and Krishnamachari, Kennedy reaffirmed the desire to aid India economically and militarily. He told them that an air defense program, along with the other assistance the US was providing, would deter China. He believed that "the greater the evidence of US interest, it would seem the more restrained the Chinese Communists will be." An air defense agreement would also minimize the negative reaction from Pakistan. Furthermore, the US was interested in ensuring that India had the ability to defend itself, and air defense gave the US time to help India get to that point. Finally, it would "give the substance of alignment without the fact of it."[81]

On July 9, 1963, Galbraith delivered to Foreign Secretary M. J. Desai a proposal for air defense that subsequently resulted in the Air Defense Agreement of 1963. The US agreed to provide India with two mobile radar installations, eventually to be manned by US-trained Indian technical personnel, and subsequently six permanent radar installations. The proposal also envisioned joint air force training exercises and, finally, that "the United States Government [would] consult with the Government of India, in the event of a Chinese Communist attack on India, regarding possible United States assistance in strengthening India's air defenses."[82] In internal administration discussions, Rusk had explained that the proposal did "not involve a firm mutual defense commitment," something India would not accept because of the implication for its foreign policy. However, in response to a question from Kennedy, he confirmed, "'consult' actually means a commitment to defend" on the part of the US.[83]

The Indian government agreed to the proposal and signed the Air Defense Agreement with the US.[84] It was announced, along with news of a joint exercise, which the American, Australian, British, and Indian air forces subsequently undertook in November 1963.[85] China publicly criticized the Indian decision. Following on Zhou's earlier statement that the "non-aligned country has become an aligned country," Beijing asserted that nonalignment had become a "laughing stock."[86]